John 1 - 3

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Prophecy Fulfilled (WEB)

Matthew opens with a genealogy. Mark opens with a man in the desert. Luke opens with a historian clearing his throat.

John opens before the universe.

In the beginning was the Word - which is the first line of Genesis, picked up and carried somewhere Genesis did not go.

And the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

Light that darkness cannot put out. A world made by Him that did not recognise Him. His own people, who did not receive Him.

And then the sentence the whole book is built on: the Word became flesh and pitched His tent among us.

Then a man in the wilderness who will not claim a single title. Not the Christ. Not Elijah. Not the prophet. Only a voice.

And when he finally points, what he says is: behold, the Lamb of God.

Then four days of men finding other men. Andrew finds Simon. Philip finds Nathanael. Come and see - said twice, by two different people, and it is the only invitation anybody issues in this chapter.

And a man under a fig tree is told he will see heaven opened and the angels going up and down on the Son of Man - which is Jacob's dream, with a Person where the ladder was.

Then a wedding that runs out of wine, and six stone jars meant for washing, and a mother's last recorded words in Scripture: whatever He says to you, do it.

A hundred and something gallons of water for ritual purification, turned into the good wine at somebody's wedding.

Then a whip of cords, and tables going over, and the first thing He ever calls the temple: my Father's house.

Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up - and John tells us plainly that nobody understood it until after.

Then a ruler of the Jews, at night, who says we know - and is told he must be born from above.

Wind that goes where it wants. A serpent on a pole in the wilderness. And the verse the whole world can quote and almost nobody reads slowly.

And then an old friend of the bridegroom, standing in the dark at the edge of the party, listening for a voice, and saying the hardest sentence a successful man ever says.

He must increase. I must decrease.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 1 - The Word Made Flesh, a Voice That Claims Nothing, and Come and See

Key Notes

- “In the beginning” is the first phrase of Genesis, quoted deliberately. John is not starting his book; he is starting the book, and going back further than Genesis does (John 1:1).
- Logos was a live word in two worlds at once. To a Greek it was the ordering principle behind everything; to a Jew it was the davar, the word by which God creates and by which prophets are addressed, and the Aramaic paraphrases used it as a way of speaking about God Himself acting. John picks the one word that lands in both rooms (John 1:1).
- “The Word was God” lacks the article before God in the Greek, which is sometimes offered as a reason to read a god. But Greek regularly drops the article from a predicate noun standing before its verb, and John writes the same construction elsewhere without anyone reading it that way. The grammar is worth knowing rather than shouting about (John 1:1).
- Verse 3 is deliberately airtight: all things were made through him, and without him not one thing was made that has been made. There is no category left over (John 1:3).
- The verb in verse 5 can mean overcome or grasp, and both senses are alive in it - the darkness neither put the light out nor understood it. The WEB prints overcome (John 1:5).
- The witness is introduced before the incarnation is stated. John the Baptist arrives in verse 6, eight verses before the Word becomes flesh, because in this Gospel testimony always comes first (John 1:6-8).
- Verse 11 uses two different forms: he came to his own things - his own place - and his own people did not receive him (John 1:11).
- “He gave the right to become God’s children” is exousia, authority, and the birth is defined by three negations: not of blood, not of the will of the flesh, not of the will of a man (John 1:12-13).
- “Lived among us” is eskenosen - he pitched his tent, he tabernacled. The word is built on the tent in the wilderness, and the next clause, we saw his glory, is what filled it (John 1:14).
- “Grace and truth” is the Hebrew pair chesed and emet - loyal love and faithfulness - which is what Yahweh proclaimed over Moses on the mountain. Three verses later Moses is named by name (John 1:14, 17).
- Verse 17 is not law bad, grace good. The law was given through Moses; grace and truth came into being through Yahshua. One was handed down and the other arrived in person (John 1:17).
- “In the bosom of the Father” is the position of the honoured guest reclining next to the host at a meal. John uses the same phrase later of the disciple leaning on Yahshua (John 1:18, 13:23).
- The delegation asks three questions in descending order of expectation: the Christ, Elijah, the prophet of Deuteronomy 18. John says no to all three (John 1:19-21).

- He denies being Elijah, and Yahshua later says he came in the spirit and power of Elijah. Both are true at different levels - he is not the returned prophet, and he is doing the work Malachi described. This book flags the tension rather than flattening it (John 1:21, Luke 1:17).
- The only identity he claims is a sound. I am a voice. Not a title, not an office - the noise somebody makes ahead of a king (John 1:23).
- Loosening a sandal was slave work, and rabbinic tradition held that a Hebrew slave could not be made to do it. He says he is not fit for the job a slave would be spared (John 1:27).
- "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world" appears nowhere else in the Gospels. Which lamb is not specified - the Passover lamb, which was not a sin offering; the silent lamb of Isaiah 53; the daily offering in the temple; the ram caught for Isaac. The ambiguity may well be the point (John 1:29).
- The opening chapter is dated in days - the next day, the next day, again the next day - and chapter 2 opens on the third day after that. Counted through, it makes a week. Many readers see a creation week deliberately laid over the start of the Gospel; the text does not say so outright (John 1:29, 35, 43, 2:1).
- "It was about the tenth hour" is four in the afternoon. Nothing in the story depends on it, which is exactly why it reads like something somebody remembered (John 1:39).
- Andrew first finds his own brother. That is the shape of the whole chapter - found, and then brought. Nobody in it is argued into anything (John 1:41-42).
- John translates Rabbi, Messiah and Cephas for his reader. He is writing for people who do not have the Aramaic (John 1:38, 41, 42).
- Nazareth is never mentioned anywhere in the Hebrew Scriptures, and Nathanael is from Cana, the next village over. His remark is small-town rivalry rather than theology (John 1:46, 21:2).
- "An Israelite in whom is no deceit" is a pointed thing to say, because Israel was the name given to a man whose whole early life was deceit - and the promise three verses later is Jacob's dream (John 1:47, 51).
- Being under a fig tree is sometimes read as rabbinic shorthand for studying Torah. It may be. The text simply says he was there and that he was seen (John 1:48).
- The last verse is Genesis 28 with a Person where the ladder was - heaven opened, and the angels ascending and descending on the Son of Man. And the you is plural: the promise is to all of them (John 1:51).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
In the Beginning	John 1:1 • Genesis 1:1 • Proverbs 8:22-30
All Things Made Through Him	John 1:3 • Psalm 33:6 • Isaiah 44:24
He Tabernacled Among Us	John 1:14 • Exodus 40:34-35 • Ezekiel 37:27

Topic	References
Grace and Truth	John 1:14 • Exodus 34:6 • Psalm 85:10
No One Has Seen God	John 1:18 • Exodus 33:20 • Deuteronomy 4:12
Are You Elijah?	John 1:21 • Malachi 4:5 • Deuteronomy 18:15
The Voice in the Wilderness	John 1:23 • Isaiah 40:3 • Malachi 3:1
An Israelite Without Deceit	John 1:47 • Genesis 27:35 • Psalm 32:2

Prophecy Fulfilled

Fulfillment	References
The Light the Darkness Cannot Put Out	John 1:5 • Isaiah 9:2 • Isaiah 60:1-3
The Glory We Have Seen	John 1:14 • Isaiah 6:1-3 • Exodus 33:18-19
The Lamb of God	John 1:29 • Isaiah 53:7 • Exodus 12:3-6
The Spirit Descending and Remaining	John 1:32-33 • Isaiah 11:2 • Isaiah 42:1
Of Whom Moses and the Prophets Wrote	John 1:45 • Deuteronomy 18:18 • Isaiah 7:14
The Son of God, the King of Israel	John 1:49 • Psalm 2:6-7 • Zephaniah 3:15
The Ladder Between Heaven and Earth	John 1:51 • Genesis 28:12 • Daniel 7:13

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - John 1 Commentary (David Guzik) - the prologue, the witness of John, and the first disciples
- Life, Hope and Truth - The Gospel of John - John's signs, the I AM sayings, and why this Gospel differs from the other three
- Verse By Verse Ministry International - The Gospel of John, Lesson 1A - exposition of the prologue and the testimony of John the Baptist

John 1 - Opening Intro

Every other Gospel starts somewhere you can stand.

Matthew starts with a family tree. Mark starts with a man in a desert. Luke starts with a historian telling you how he did his research.

John starts before there was anywhere to stand.

In the beginning was the Word.

And every Jewish listener heard that and knew exactly which sentence he was quoting. In the beginning God created. He is picking up Genesis 1 and carrying it back past the first day.

And the Word was with God - which means alongside, face to face - and the Word was God.

Now that word, Logos, is doing something clever, and it is worth knowing why He picked it. To a Greek, the Logos was the reason behind the universe, the pattern that holds it together. To a Jew, the word of Yahweh is how the world got made in the first place - He spoke, and it was. And in the Aramaic paraphrases people used in synagogue, the Word of the Lord was a way of talking about God acting without saying God directly.

So John picks the one term that lands in both rooms at once. And then he says the thing neither room was ready for.

The Word became flesh.

And the verb there is not lived. It is pitched a tent. Tabernacled. He camped among us.

Which is the wilderness. That is the tent in the middle of the camp, with the glory over it that Moses could not walk into.

And then: we beheld His glory.

The thing that filled the tent moved into a body and walked around Galilee.

And look at what pairs with it - full of grace and truth. Now, in Hebrew those are two very particular words, chesed and emet, loyal covenant love and faithfulness, and they are the words God says about Himself when He walks past Moses on the mountain.

Which is why three verses later Moses gets named. The law was given through Moses. Grace and truth came through Yahshua the Messiah.

And hear that carefully, because it gets misused. That is not law bad, grace good. The law was given - handed down, delivered. Grace and truth came into being, arrived, showed up in a person. The same God, and the second one has a face.

Then the man in the wilderness, and I love how he handles an interrogation.

They send a delegation. Are you the Christ? No. Are you Elijah? I am not. Are you the prophet? No.

Three chances at a title, and he turns down all three.

So what is left? Who are you? Give us something to take back.

I am a voice.

That is all he will claim. Not a prophet, not an office, not a name. A noise somebody makes before a king arrives.

And then he says the sentence that puts the whole book in one line: behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world.

And notice he does not say which lamb, and there were several to choose from. Passover. Isaiah 53. The lamb offered every morning and evening in the temple. The ram caught in the thicket when Abraham raised the knife.

He does not narrow it down. Maybe because it is all of them.

Then the rest of the chapter is just people finding people.

Andrew hears John and follows. Then Andrew finds his brother Simon. Then Philip finds Nathanael.

And when Nathanael sneers - can anything good come out of Nazareth - Philip does not argue with him. He says come and see.

That is the second time that phrase appears in the chapter. It is what Yahshua said to the first two. There is no debate in this chapter at all. Just: come and look at Him.

And by the way, Nathanael is from Cana, which is the next village over. That is not theology, that is two small towns who think they are better than each other.

And He looks at him and says: behold, an Israelite in whom there is no deceit.

Which is a loaded compliment, because Israel is the name given to a man whose entire early life was deceit. Jacob stole a blessing wearing his brother's clothes.

And Nathanael says, how do you know me? And He says: before Philip called you, when you were under the fig tree, I saw you.

And whatever happened under that tree - and we are not told - it is enough to fold the man in half. Rabbi, you are the Son of God, you are the King of Israel.

And the answer to that is: you think that was something? You will see heaven opened and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man.

Which is Jacob's dream. The ladder at Bethel, with the traffic going up and down between heaven and earth.

Except there is no ladder in this version. There is a Person.

Before we read - notice that in this whole chapter nobody is convinced by an argument. They are pointed at, and then invited. Come and see is the only apologetic anyone uses.

John 1:1-51 (WEB)

1 In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.[1]

2 The same was in the beginning with God.

3 All things were made through him. Without him was not anything made that has been made.[2]

4 In him was life, and the life was the light of men.

5 The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness hasn't overcome it.[3]

6 There came a man, sent from God, whose name was John.

7 The same came as a witness, that he might testify about the light, that all might believe through him.

8 He was not the light, but was sent that he might testify about the light.

9 The true light that enlightens everyone was coming into the world.

10 He was in the world, and the world was made through him, and the world didn't recognize him.

11 He came to his own, and those who were his own didn't receive him.

12 But as many as received him, to them he gave the right to become God's children, to those who believe in his name:

13 who were born not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God.

14 The Word became flesh, and lived among us. We saw his glory, such glory as of the one and only Son of the Father, full of grace and truth.[4]

15 John testified about him. He cried out, saying, "This was he of whom I said, 'He who comes after me has surpassed me, for he was before me.'"

16 From his fullness we all received grace upon grace.

17 For the law was given through Moses. Grace and truth were realized through Jesus Christ.[5]

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[1] **Cross-Reference:** Genesis 1:1 • Proverbs 8:22-30 - *in the beginning God created, and wisdom present as a craftsman when he marked out the foundations*

[2] **Cross-Reference:** Psalm 33:6 • Isaiah 44:24 - *by Yahweh's word the heavens were made, and the one who stretched out the heavens alone*

[3] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Isaiah 9:2 • Isaiah 60:1-3 - *the people walking in darkness who have seen a great light, and nations coming to the brightness of your rising*

[4] **Cross-Reference:** Exodus 40:34-35 • Exodus 34:6 - *the glory filling the tabernacle so that Moses could not enter, and Yahweh proclaiming himself abundant in loving kindness and truth*

[5] **Cross-Reference:** Exodus 24:12 • Psalm 85:10 - *the tablets given to Moses on the mountain, and loving kindness and truth meeting together*

18 No one has seen God at any time. The one and only Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, he has declared him.[6]

19 This is John's testimony, when the Jews sent priests and Levites from Jerusalem to ask him, "Who are you?"

20 He declared, and didn't deny, but he declared, "I am not the Christ."

21 They asked him, "What then? Are you Elijah?" He said, "I am not." "Are you the prophet?" He answered, "No."[7]

22 They said therefore to him, "Who are you? Give us an answer to take back to those who sent us. What do you say about yourself?"

23 He said, "I am the voice of one crying in the wilderness, 'Make straight the way of the Lord,' as Isaiah the prophet said."[8]

24 The ones who had been sent were from the Pharisees.

25 They asked him, "Why then do you baptize, if you are not the Christ, nor Elijah, nor the prophet?"

26 John answered them, "I baptize in water, but among you stands one whom you don't know.

27 He is the one who comes after me, who is preferred before me, whose sandal strap I'm not worthy to loosen."

28 These things were done in Bethany beyond the Jordan, where John was baptizing.

29 The next day, he saw Jesus coming to him, and said, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world![9]

30 This is he of whom I said, 'After me comes a man who is preferred before me, for he was before me.'

31 I didn't know him, but for this reason I came baptizing in water: that he would be revealed to Israel."

32 John testified, saying, "I have seen the Spirit descending like a dove out of heaven, and it remained on him.[10]

33 I didn't recognize him, but he who sent me to baptize in water, he said to me, 'On whomever you will see the Spirit descending, and remaining on him, the same is he who baptizes in the Holy Spirit.'

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[6] **Cross-Reference:** Exodus 33:20 • Deuteronomy 4:12 - *no man may see me and live, and a voice heard with no form seen*

[7] **Cross-Reference:** Malachi 4:5 • Deuteronomy 18:15 - *Elijah sent before the great and terrible day, and a prophet like Moses whom you shall listen to*

[8] **Cross-Reference:** Isaiah 40:3 • Malachi 3:1 - *a voice crying in the wilderness to prepare the way, and the messenger sent before the face*

[9] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Isaiah 53:7 • Exodus 12:3-6 - *led as a lamb to the slaughter, and a lamb without blemish kept until the fourteenth day*

[10] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Isaiah 11:2 • Isaiah 42:1 - *the Spirit of Yahweh resting on him, and my chosen in whom my soul delights*

34 I have seen, and have testified that this is the Son of God."

35 Again, the next day, John was standing with two of his disciples,

36 and he looked at Jesus as he walked, and said, "Behold, the Lamb of God!"

37 The two disciples heard him speak, and they followed Jesus.

38 Jesus turned, and saw them following, and said to them, "What are you looking for?" They said to him, "Rabbi" (which is to say, being interpreted, Teacher), "where are you staying?"

39 He said to them, "Come, and see." They came and saw where he was staying, and they stayed with him that day. It was about the tenth hour.

40 One of the two who heard John, and followed him, was Andrew, Simon Peter's brother.

41 He first found his own brother, Simon, and said to him, "We have found the Messiah!" (which is, being interpreted, Christ).

42 He brought him to Jesus. Jesus looked at him, and said, "You are Simon the son of Jonah. You shall be called Cephas" (which is by interpretation, Peter).

43 On the next day, he was determined to go out into Galilee, and he found Philip. Jesus said to him, "Follow me."

44 Now Philip was from Bethsaida, of the city of Andrew and Peter.

45 Philip found Nathanael, and said to him, "We have found him, of whom Moses in the law, and the prophets, wrote: Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph."[11]

46 Nathanael said to him, "Can any good thing come out of Nazareth?" Philip said to him, "Come and see."

47 Jesus saw Nathanael coming to him, and said about him, "Behold, an Israelite indeed, in whom is no deceit!"

48 Nathanael said to him, "How do you know me?" Jesus answered him, "Before Philip called you, when you were under the fig tree, I saw you."

49 Nathanael answered him, "Rabbi, you are the Son of God! You are King of Israel!"[12]

50 Jesus answered him, "Because I told you, 'I saw you underneath the fig tree,' do you believe? You will see greater things than these!"

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[11] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Deuteronomy 18:18 • Isaiah 7:14 - *a prophet raised up from among their brothers, and the virgin who conceives and bears a son*

[12] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Psalm 2:6-7 • Zephaniah 3:15 - *my king set on my holy hill, and the King of Israel in the midst of her*

51 He said to him, “Most certainly, I tell you all, hereafter you will see heaven opened, and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man.”[13]

[13] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Genesis 28:12 • Daniel 7:13 - *the ladder with angels ascending and descending, and one like a son of man coming with the clouds*

CHAPTER 2 - Six Stone Jars, a Whip of Cords, and a Temple Raised in Three Days

Key Notes

- “The third day” counts on from the days marked through chapter 1. Taken together the opening runs to seven, which many readers take as a creation week laid over the beginning of the Gospel (John 2:1, 1:29).
- Cana appears only in John, and the one man we know from there is Nathanael, who was called two days earlier (John 2:1, 21:2).
- “Woman” sounds cold in English and was not rude in Greek - He uses the same address to her from the cross. But it is not mother either, and the distance in it is real (John 2:4, 19:26).
- “What does that have to do with you and me” is a Hebrew idiom that turns up in Samuel and Kings. It means this is not a matter we share, and it is not affectionate (John 2:4).
- “My hour has not yet come” is the first of a series. The hour finally arrives when He says the hour has come for the Son of Man to be glorified - and He means the cross (John 2:4, 12:23).
- Whatever he says to you, do it, is the last thing His mother says in the whole of Scripture. She is not recorded speaking again (John 2:5).
- The jars are stone rather than clay because stone does not contract ritual impurity - which is why the vessels for purification water were made of it. Two or three metretes apiece puts the total somewhere near a hundred and twenty gallons (John 2:6).
- He takes the water kept for ceremonial washing and makes it the wine of a wedding. Nothing is destroyed and nothing is condemned; the same water is put to a better use (John 2:7-9).
- There were six jars. Seven is the number that would have been complete (John 2:6).
- The master of the feast does not know where it came from; the servants who drew it do. In this Gospel knowledge keeps landing on the people who did what they were told (John 2:9).
- The compliment goes to a bridegroom who did nothing. The next chapter will name who the bridegroom actually is (John 2:10, 3:29).
- John calls it a sign - semeion - not a mighty work, which is the Synoptics’ usual word. A mighty work displays power; a sign points away from itself at something else (John 2:11).
- John puts the clearing of the temple at the start of the ministry and the other three put it at the end. Either there were two, three years apart, or John has placed it here for reasons of theme rather than sequence. Both readings have serious defenders and this book does not settle it (John 2:13-16).
- The whip is only in John, and read closely it is used on the animals. To the men selling doves He speaks instead - and doves were the offering of the poor, so scattering those birds would have cost the poorest people in the court their sacrifice (John 2:15-16).

- “My Father’s house” is the first claim He makes in this Gospel, and it is a claim about sonship as much as about trading. Luke has Him using almost the same words at twelve years old (John 2:16, Luke 2:49).
- The disciples remember Psalm 69, which is quoted more often in the New Testament than almost any other psalm, and always about suffering (John 2:17).
- “Destroy this temple” is an imperative. He is not proposing it; He is telling them what they are going to do (John 2:19).
- Forty-six years puts the conversation around AD 27 or 28, since Herod’s rebuilding began around 20 BC. It is one of the firmest chronological pegs in the Gospels (John 2:20).
- Verse 21 is John’s own note, added long afterwards - he spoke of the temple of his body - and verse 22 admits that nobody understood it at the time (John 2:21-22).
- The last three verses are a warning attached to a success. Many believed when they saw the signs, and He did not entrust Himself to them. It is the same verb both ways: they believed in Him, and He did not believe in them (John 2:23-24).
- “He knew what was in man” closes the chapter - and the next word in the Gospel is Nicodemus, a man arriving with a carefully prepared opening line (John 2:25, 3:1).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Whatever He Says to You, Do It	John 2:5 • Genesis 41:55 • Exodus 24:7
Vessels for Purifying	John 2:6 • Numbers 19:17-19 • Leviticus 11:32-33
Wine at the Feast	John 2:10 • Psalm 104:14-15 • Isaiah 25:6
A House of Prayer, Not a Market	John 2:16 • Isaiah 56:7 • Zechariah 14:21
Zeal for Your House	John 2:17 • Psalm 69:9 • Psalm 119:139
By What Sign?	John 2:18 • Deuteronomy 18:21-22 • Isaiah 7:11
Raised on the Third Day	John 2:19 • Hosea 6:2 • Psalm 16:10
He Knew What Was in Man	John 2:25 • 1 Samuel 16:7 • Jeremiah 17:9-10

Prophecy Fulfilled

Fulfillment	References
The Bridegroom at the Feast	John 2:9 • Isaiah 62:5 • Hosea 2:19-20
The Wine of the Age to Come	John 2:10 • Amos 9:13-14 • Joel 3:18
Glory Revealed in a Sign	John 2:11 • Isaiah 35:1-2 • Habakkuk 2:14
The Lord Comes Suddenly to His Temple	John 2:15 • Malachi 3:1-3 • Zechariah 14:21
Zeal Has Consumed Me	John 2:17 • Psalm 69:9 • Psalm 69:20-21

Fulfillment	References
A Temple Not Built by Hands	John 2:19 • Ezekiel 37:26-27 • Isaiah 28:16
He Searches the Heart	John 2:24 • Psalm 139:1-4 • 1 Chronicles 28:9

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - John 2 Commentary (David Guzik) - the wedding at Cana, the first sign, and the cleansing of the temple
- Life, Hope and Truth - The Gospel of John - the seven signs and what John means by belief
- Verse By Verse Ministry International - The Gospel of John, Lesson 2 - exposition of Cana and the first Passover of the ministry

John 2 - Opening Intro

A wedding in a village nobody has heard of, and the catering fails.

And we should understand how bad that was. A village wedding was the party of the decade, it ran for days, and the family had one job. Running out of wine was not an inconvenience. It was a humiliation the town would still be talking about in twenty years.

And His mother comes to Him and says four words: they have no wine.

She does not ask for anything. She just tells Him.

And His answer sounds harsh in English. Woman, what does that have to do with you and me? My hour has not yet come.

Woman is not rude in Greek - He says the same word to her from the cross. But it is not mother, either. Something has shifted between them, and He is telling her so.

And that phrase - what have I to do with you - is an old Hebrew idiom. It turns up in Samuel and in Kings, and it means: this is not something we share.

And my hour has not yet come. Hold that phrase, because it runs all the way through this Gospel like a clock ticking, and when the hour finally comes in chapter 12, it is the cross.

And then she does something remarkable. She does not argue. She turns to the servants and says: whatever He tells you, do it.

And those are the last words Mary speaks anywhere in the Bible. She never gets another line. And that is the line she goes out on.

Six stone water jars. And the detail matters twice over.

Stone, because stone cannot become ritually unclean - which is exactly why the water for purification was kept in it.

And six. Not seven.

Twenty or thirty gallons each. Call it a hundred and twenty gallons of water, sitting there for washing hands.

Fill them. And they fill them to the brim.

And He takes the water of ritual purification and turns it into the wine of a wedding feast.

He does not smash the jars. He does not lecture anybody about ceremony. He fills them up and makes them better.

And nobody sees it happen. There is no moment, no gesture, no word of command over the water. Only a servant dipping a cup.

And the master of the feast tastes it and does not know where it came from - but the servants who drew the water knew.

That is going to keep happening in this book. The people who did what they were told are the people who know.

And he congratulates the bridegroom, who had nothing to do with it. Which is quietly funny, and it is also a set-up, because in the very next chapter we find out who the bridegroom actually is.

John calls it the beginning of His signs. Not miracles - signs. A miracle shows you power. A sign points at something past itself.

Then Jerusalem, and the tables.

Now a fair question: Matthew, Mark and Luke all put this at the end, in the last week. John puts it here at the start. Either it happened twice, three years apart, or John has moved it for a reason. Serious people hold both, and I am not going to pretend to settle it tonight.

But look at what He actually does. He makes a whip of cords - only John tells us that - and He drives out the animals. And to the men selling doves He speaks instead of driving.

Because doves were the offering of the poor. Turn those loose and a poor family has lost what they came with.

Even overturning the temple, He is careful about who pays.

And what He calls it is the thing to catch: my Father’s house.

That is the first claim He makes in this Gospel. Not I am a prophet. My Father’s house.

And they ask for a sign, which is a fair question - who authorised this?

Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up.

And notice that is an imperative. Destroy it. He is not proposing a demolition. He is telling them what they are going to do.

And they laugh - forty-six years to build this, and you will do it in three days? Which, by the way, is a useful date. That puts this conversation around AD 27 or 28.

And John adds the note: but He spoke of the temple of His body. And then, honestly - when He was raised from the dead, His disciples remembered.

They did not get it either. Not until after.

And the chapter ends on a warning that is easy to walk past. Many believed in His name when they saw the signs. But Jesus did not entrust Himself to them, because He knew all men.

It is the same word both ways. They believed in Him. He did not believe in them.

Before we read - notice that the first sign in this Gospel is not a healing or a resurrection. It is a hundred and twenty gallons of water for washing, turned into the best wine anyone at that party had ever tasted. He did not throw out the old thing. He filled it and transformed it.

John 2:1-25 (WEB)

1 The third day, there was a marriage in Cana of Galilee. Jesus' mother was there.

2 Jesus also was invited, with his disciples, to the marriage.

3 When the wine ran out, Jesus' mother said to him, "They have no wine."

4 Jesus said to her, "Woman, what does that have to do with you and me? My hour has not yet come."

5 His mother said to the servants, "Whatever he says to you, do it."[14]

6 Now there were six water pots of stone set there after the Jews' way of purifying, containing two or three metretes apiece.[15]

7 Jesus said to them, "Fill the water pots with water." They filled them up to the brim.

8 He said to them, "Now draw some out, and take it to the ruler of the feast." So they took it.

9 When the ruler of the feast tasted the water now become wine, and didn't know where it came from (but the servants who had drawn the water knew), the ruler of the feast called the bridegroom,[16]

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[14] **Cross-Reference:** Genesis 41:55 • Exodus 24:7 - *go to Joseph, and whatever he says to you, do it; and all that Yahweh has spoken we will do*

[15] **Cross-Reference:** Numbers 19:17-19 • Leviticus 11:32-33 - *running water for cleansing the unclean, and the earthen vessel that must be broken*

[16] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Isaiah 62:5 • Hosea 2:19-20 - *as a bridegroom rejoices over his bride, and I will betroth you to me forever*

10 and said to him, “Everyone serves the good wine first, and when the guests have drunk freely, then that which is worse. You have kept the good wine until now!”[17]

11 This beginning of his signs Jesus did in Cana of Galilee, and revealed his glory; and his disciples believed in him.[18]

12 After this, he went down to Capernaum, he, and his mother, his brothers, and his disciples; and they stayed there a few days.

13 The Passover of the Jews was at hand, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem.

14 He found in the temple those who sold oxen, sheep, and doves, and the changers of money sitting.

15 He made a whip of cords, and threw all out of the temple, both the sheep and the oxen; and he poured out the changers’ money, and overthrew their tables.[19]

16 To those who sold the doves, he said, “Take these things out of here! Don’t make my Father’s house a marketplace!”[20]

17 His disciples remembered that it was written, “Zeal for your house will eat me up.”[21]

18 The Jews therefore answered him, “What sign do you show us, seeing that you do these things?”[22]

19 Jesus answered them, “Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up.”[23]

20 The Jews therefore said, “It took forty-six years to build this temple! Will you raise it up in three days?”

21 But he spoke of the temple of his body.

22 When therefore he was raised from the dead, his disciples remembered that he said this, and they believed the Scripture, and the word which Jesus had said.[24]

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[17] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Amos 9:13-14 • Joel 3:18 - *the mountains dropping sweet wine, and the hills flowing with milk*

[18] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Isaiah 35:1-2 • Habakkuk 2:14 - *they shall see the glory of Yahweh, and the earth filled with the knowledge of his glory*

[19] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Malachi 3:1-3 • Zechariah 14:21 - *the Lord coming suddenly to his temple to purify the sons of Levi, and no trader left in the house*

[20] **Cross-Reference:** Isaiah 56:7 • Psalm 93:5 - *my house shall be called a house of prayer, and holiness befits your house forever*

[21] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Psalm 69:9 • Psalm 69:20-21 - *zeal for your house has eaten me up, and reproach breaking the heart, with vinegar for the thirst*

[22] **Cross-Reference:** Deuteronomy 18:21-22 • Isaiah 7:11 - *how to know a word Yahweh has not spoken, and a sign asked for as deep as Sheol*

[23] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Ezekiel 37:26-27 • Hosea 6:2 - *my sanctuary set among them forever, and on the third day he will raise us up*

[24] **Cross-Reference:** Psalm 16:10 • Isaiah 28:16 - *you will not leave my soul in Sheol, and a tried stone laid as a sure foundation*

23 Now when he was in Jerusalem at the Passover, during the feast, many believed in his name, observing his signs which he did.

24 But Jesus didn't entrust himself to them, because he knew everyone,[25]

25 and because he didn't need for anyone to testify concerning man; for he himself knew what was in man.[26]

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[25] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Psalm 139:1-4 • 1 Chronicles 28:9 - *you have searched me and know my thoughts from far off, and Yahweh searches all hearts*

[26] **Cross-Reference:** 1 Samuel 16:7 • Jeremiah 17:9-10 - *man looks at the outward appearance but Yahweh at the heart, and I search the heart and test the mind*

CHAPTER 3 - Born From Above, a Serpent Lifted in the Wilderness, and He Must Increase

Key Notes

- The chapter break hides a joint. Chapter 2 ends with He knew what was in man, and the next sentence introduces a man with a carefully prepared opening line (John 3:1, 2:25).
- Nicodemus is a Pharisee and a ruler - which means the Sanhedrin - and in verse 10 he is called the teacher of Israel, with the article. He is not a curious layman (John 3:1, 10).
- He comes at night. In a Gospel that runs on light and darkness, the detail is not neutral - and Nicodemus appears twice more, the last time in daylight with seventy-five pounds of spices for a burial (John 3:2, 7:50, 19:39).
- “We know” is plural. He is speaking for other people who have reached the same conclusion and have not said so out loud (John 3:2).
- The word behind born anew is anothen, which means both again and from above. Nicodemus hears the first; Yahshua means the second; and the whole exchange runs on the ambiguity. It works in Greek and not in Aramaic, which raises a fair question about what language this conversation was held in. The text does not answer it (John 3:3-4).
- “Born of water and spirit” has been read as natural birth then spiritual birth, as baptism, and as Ezekiel 36 - I will sprinkle clean water on you, and I will put my Spirit within you. The last of those is a passage the teacher of Israel would be expected to know, which fits the rebuke that follows (John 3:5, 10).
- Wind and spirit are one word in Greek, and one word in Hebrew too. The saying only works because they are the same word (John 3:8).
- “You hear its sound but don’t know where it comes from” - the wind is known by its effects and not by its origin, and so is everyone born of the Spirit (John 3:8).
- “Are you the teacher of Israel and don’t understand these things?” assumes the new birth was already there in the Hebrew Scriptures to be understood. He is not being told he missed a new doctrine; he is being told he missed his own (John 3:10).
- “Who is in heaven” at the end of verse 13 is present in many manuscripts and absent from others. The WEB prints it (John 3:13).
- The bronze serpent is Numbers 21. The people are dying of snakebite, and what God tells Moses to lift up is a snake - an image of the very thing killing them. They are not healed by looking away but by looking at it (John 3:14).
- That serpent later had to be destroyed, because Israel started burning incense to it. The cure became an idol within a few centuries (John 3:14, 2 Kings 18:4).
- “Lifted up” is hypsoo, and in this Gospel it always carries both meanings at once - lifted onto a cross, and lifted into glory. He never separates them (John 3:14, 8:28, 12:32).

- “God so loved the world” is houtos - in this way, in this manner. The verse is about how God loved, not only how much (John 3:16).
- “One and only” is monogenes - unique, one of a kind. It is a statement about there being no second, rather than about origin (John 3:16, 18).
- The judgment in verse 19 is not a sentence handed down but a preference already exercised: the light came, and men loved the darkness. The verdict is what people did with it (John 3:19).
- Where the quotation ends is a real question. The Greek has no quotation marks, and verse 15 and verse 21 are both defensible as the last words spoken to Nicodemus. The WEB closes it at 21 (John 3:15-21).
- “Jesus baptized” in verse 22 is corrected a chapter later, where John notes that in fact His disciples did the baptizing, not He Himself (John 3:22, 4:2).
- Enon near Salim, because there was much water there, is the kind of detail a traveller remembers and a theologian would not invent (John 3:23).
- “For John was not yet thrown into prison” is a quiet correction of the impression the other Gospels leave, where John’s arrest comes before the ministry begins (John 3:24).
- The friend of the bridegroom was a real office - he arranged the marriage, made the negotiations, and stood aside on the day. His whole joy is in hearing the bridegroom’s voice, which means his success is his own redundancy (John 3:29).
- “He must increase, but I must decrease” is the last thing John the Baptist says in this Gospel. He goes out on a sentence about becoming smaller (John 3:30).
- Whether verses 31 to 36 are still John speaking or the writer’s own commentary is disputed, and the text gives no marker either way (John 3:31-36).
- “The wrath of God remains on him” is a present continuous verb. The wrath is not described as arriving later; it is described as already resting, and belief is what lifts it (John 3:36).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Born of Water and Spirit	John 3:5 • Ezekiel 36:25-27 • Jeremiah 31:33
The Wind Goes Where It Wants	John 3:8 • Ecclesiastes 11:5 • Ezekiel 37:9
The Teacher of Israel	John 3:10 • Isaiah 29:11-12 • Malachi 2:7
The Serpent on the Pole	John 3:14 • Numbers 21:8-9 • 2 Kings 18:4
Light Come Into the World	John 3:19 • Isaiah 9:2 • Job 24:13-17
Nothing Received Unless Given	John 3:27 • 1 Chronicles 29:14 • Daniel 2:21
The Voice of the Bridegroom	John 3:29 • Jeremiah 33:11 • Isaiah 62:5
The Spirit Without Measure	John 3:34 • Isaiah 11:2 • Isaiah 61:1

Prophecy Fulfilled

Fulfillment	References
A New Heart and a New Spirit	John 3:3 • Ezekiel 11:19-20 • Deuteronomy 30:6
He Who Came Down From Heaven	John 3:13 • Proverbs 30:4 • Daniel 7:13
Lifted Up As the Serpent Was	John 3:14 • Numbers 21:8-9 • Isaiah 52:13
He Gave His Only Son	John 3:16 • Genesis 22:2 • Isaiah 53:6
Sent Not to Judge but to Save	John 3:17 • Ezekiel 33:11 • Isaiah 49:6
The Bridegroom's Voice Restored	John 3:29 • Jeremiah 33:11 • Hosea 2:19-20
All Things Given Into His Hand	John 3:35 • Daniel 7:14 • Psalm 8:6

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - John 3 Commentary (David Guzik) - Nicodemus, the new birth, and the last testimony of John the Baptist
- Life, Hope and Truth - The Gospel of John - what John means by belief, life, and being born from above
- Verse By Verse Ministry International - The Gospel of John, Lesson 3A - exposition of the night conversation with Nicodemus

John 3 - Opening Intro

Chapter 2 ends with a sentence, and chapter 3 begins with a man, and our Bibles have put a number between them that hides the joke.

He knew all men, and He knew what was in man.

Now there was a man of the Pharisees named Nicodemus.

And in he comes with his opening line all polished up: Rabbi, we know that you are a teacher come from God, for no one can do these signs unless God is with him.

And notice we know. Plural. He is speaking for a group of people who have privately worked something out and are not saying so in daylight.

Which is why he comes at night. And in a book that is about light and darkness from the first page, that detail is doing work.

But before we are too hard on him - hold on to Nicodemus, because he turns up twice more. He speaks up for Him in front of the council in chapter 7. And in chapter 19, in broad daylight, with the disciples scattered and hiding, he walks up to a Roman cross carrying seventy-five pounds of burial spices.

The man who came in the dark is the man who buries Him in the open.

And Yahshua does not respond to the compliment at all. He goes straight through it: unless one is born anew, he cannot see the Kingdom of God.

And the word there - anothen - means two things at once. Again, and from above.

Nicodemus hears again. So his question is not stupid, it is literal: how can a man be born when he is old? Can he go back into the womb?

But the word means from above. And the entire conversation is running on that double meaning.

Unless one is born of water and the Spirit.

And people take that a few ways - natural birth then spiritual, or baptism. But watch what happens two verses later, because it tells you which one He meant.

Are you the teacher of Israel, and you do not understand these things?

That is a rebuke, and it only makes sense if this was already in the book Nicodemus taught from.

And it is. Ezekiel 36: I will sprinkle clean water on you and you shall be clean, and I will put my Spirit within you.

Water and Spirit. He is not being told he missed a new doctrine. He is being told he missed his own Bible.

Then the wind. And this one only works in the original, because pneuma is one word meaning both wind and spirit - in Greek and in Hebrew both.

The wind blows where it wishes. You hear the sound of it, but you cannot tell where it came from or where it is going. So is everyone born of the Spirit.

You do not track the wind. You notice what it moves.

And then the serpent, and this is the strangest picture in the chapter.

Numbers 21. The people are being bitten by snakes and dying, and God tells Moses to make a bronze snake and put it on a pole - and anyone who looks at it lives.

Which is not what you would design. The cure is an image of the thing that is killing them. They are not healed by looking away from it. They are healed by looking straight at it.

And there is a footnote to that story you should know. Centuries later, Israel was burning incense to that bronze snake, and Hezekiah had to smash it. The thing that saved them became the thing they worshipped.

As Moses lifted up the serpent, even so must the Son of Man be lifted up.

And lifted up in this Gospel always means two things at once. Lifted onto a cross, and lifted into glory. He never separates them. In John, the cross is the throne.

And then verse 16. And I want us to slow down, because familiarity has sanded this one smooth.

For God so loved the world.

That so is not so much. The Greek is in this way, in this manner. It is pointing back at the serpent. This is how God loved the world - He lifted His Son up where everyone dying could see Him.

And then the judgment - and hear how it is defined. This is the judgment: the light has come into the world, and men loved the darkness rather than the light.

The judgment is not a sentence being passed. It is a preference already exercised.

And then the last scene, and it is one of the most dignified things in Scripture.

John's disciples come to him, and they are hurt. Rabbi - the man you baptized, everybody is going to Him now.

They are watching their teacher's ministry drain away.

And he says: a man can receive nothing unless it has been given him from heaven.

And then he uses the picture of the shoshbin, the friend of the bridegroom. That was a real job. He arranged the marriage, he did the negotiating, he ran the day - and then he stood outside the chamber, and when he heard the bridegroom's voice, his work was over and he was glad.

The friend's success is his own redundancy.

This joy of mine is now full.

He must increase, but I must decrease.

And those are the last words John the Baptist speaks in this Gospel. He gets no farewell scene. He goes out on a sentence about becoming smaller.

Before we read - hold two men side by side tonight. A ruler who came in the dark and could not understand how a grown man starts again, and a preacher in the daylight who understood exactly what it costs to get smaller. Both of them are in the book for us.

John 3:1-36 (WEB)

1 Now there was a man of the Pharisees named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews.

2 The same came to him by night, and said to him, "Rabbi, we know that you are a teacher come from God, for no one can do these signs that you do, unless God is with him."

3 Jesus answered him, “Most certainly, I tell you, unless one is born anew, he can’t see God’s Kingdom.”[27]

4 Nicodemus said to him, “How can a man be born when he is old? Can he enter a second time into his mother’s womb, and be born?”

5 Jesus answered, “Most certainly I tell you, unless one is born of water and spirit, he can’t enter into God’s Kingdom.[28]

6 That which is born of the flesh is flesh. That which is born of the Spirit is spirit.

7 Don’t marvel that I said to you, ‘You must be born anew.’

8 The wind blows where it wants to, and you hear its sound, but don’t know where it comes from and where it is going. So is everyone who is born of the Spirit.”[29]

9 Nicodemus answered him, “How can these things be?”

10 Jesus answered him, “Are you the teacher of Israel, and don’t understand these things?[30]

11 Most certainly I tell you, we speak that which we know, and testify of that which we have seen, and you don’t receive our witness.

12 If I told you earthly things and you don’t believe, how will you believe if I tell you heavenly things?

13 No one has ascended into heaven, but he who descended out of heaven, the Son of Man, who is in heaven.[31]

14 As Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, even so must the Son of Man be lifted up,[32]

15 that whoever believes in him should not perish, but have eternal life.

16 For God so loved the world, that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish, but have eternal life.[33]

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[27] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Ezekiel 11:19-20 • Deuteronomy 30:6 - *a new heart and a new spirit put within them, and Yahweh circumcising the heart so that you may live*

[28] **Cross-Reference:** Ezekiel 36:25-27 • Jeremiah 31:33 - *clean water sprinkled and a new spirit put within you, and the law written on the heart*

[29] **Cross-Reference:** Ecclesiastes 11:5 • Ezekiel 37:9 - *you don’t know the way of the wind, and breath called from the four winds into the slain*

[30] **Cross-Reference:** Isaiah 29:11-12 • Malachi 2:7 - *a sealed book handed to a man who can read, and the priest’s lips that should keep knowledge*

[31] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Proverbs 30:4 • Daniel 7:13 - *who has ascended into heaven and descended, and one like a son of man coming with the clouds*

[32] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Numbers 21:8-9 • Isaiah 52:13 - *the bronze serpent set on a pole so that whoever looked would live, and my servant lifted up and highly exalted*

[33] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Genesis 22:2 • Isaiah 53:6 - *take your son, your only son whom you love, and Yahweh laying on him the iniquity of us all*

17 For God didn't send his Son into the world to judge the world, but that the world should be saved through him.[34]

18 He who believes in him is not judged. He who doesn't believe has been judged already, because he has not believed in the name of the one and only Son of God.

19 This is the judgment, that the light has come into the world, and men loved the darkness rather than the light; for their works were evil.[35]

20 For everyone who does evil hates the light, and doesn't come to the light, lest his works would be exposed.

21 But he who does the truth comes to the light, that his works may be revealed, that they have been done in God."

22 After these things, Jesus came with his disciples into the land of Judea. He stayed there with them, and baptized.

23 John also was baptizing in Enon near Salim, because there was much water there. They came, and were baptized.

24 For John was not yet thrown into prison.

25 There arose therefore a questioning on the part of John's disciples with some Jews about purification.

26 They came to John, and said to him, "Rabbi, he who was with you beyond the Jordan, to whom you have testified, behold, the same baptizes, and everyone is coming to him."

27 John answered, "A man can receive nothing, unless it has been given him from heaven.[36]

28 You yourselves testify that I said, 'I am not the Christ,' but, 'I have been sent before him.'

29 He who has the bride is the bridegroom; but the friend of the bridegroom, who stands and hears him, rejoices greatly because of the bridegroom's voice. This, my joy, therefore is made full.[37]

30 He must increase, but I must decrease.

31 He who comes from above is above all. He who is from the earth belongs to the earth, and speaks of the earth. He who comes from heaven is above all.

32 What he has seen and heard, of that he testifies; and no one receives his witness.

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[34] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Ezekiel 33:11 • Isaiah 49:6 - *I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked, and salvation to the end of the earth*

[35] **Cross-Reference:** Isaiah 9:2 • Job 24:13-17 - *a light shining on those in the shadow of death, and those who rebel against the light*

[36] **Cross-Reference:** 1 Chronicles 29:14 • Daniel 2:21 - *all things come from you and of your own we have given you, and God who removes and sets up kings*

[37] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Jeremiah 33:11 • Isaiah 62:5 - *the voice of the bridegroom heard again in the waste places, and your God rejoicing over you*

33 He who has received his witness has set his seal to this, that God is true.

34 For he whom God has sent speaks the words of God; for God gives the Spirit without measure.[38]

35 The Father loves the Son, and has given all things into his hand.[39]

36 One who believes in the Son has eternal life, but one who disobeys the Son won't see life, but the wrath of God remains on him."

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[38] **Cross-Reference:** Isaiah 11:2 • Isaiah 61:1 - *the Spirit of Yahweh resting on him, and the Spirit of the Lord Yahweh is on me*

[39] **Prophecy Fulfilled:** Daniel 7:14 • Psalm 8:6 - *dominion and glory given him that all peoples should serve him, and all things put under his feet*

Major Themes Across John 1-3

- A Gospel that opens before Genesis rather than at a genealogy
- One word chosen because it lands in the Greek room and the Hebrew room at once
- Light that darkness could neither put out nor understand
- A Word who pitched His tent in the middle of the camp
- Chesed and emet - the words spoken over Moses - walking around in a body
- The law handed down, and grace and truth arriving in person
- A witness who refused three titles and claimed only to be a sound
- A Lamb announced without saying which lamb, because it may be all of them
- Come and see, offered twice, and no argument made anywhere in the chapter
- Found and brought - the only evangelism method in John 1
- A man with no deceit, greeted by the name of a man who had nothing else
- Jacob's ladder with a Person where the ladder used to be
- A mother's last recorded words: whatever He says to you, do it
- Six stone jars, one short of seven, filled to the brim
- Water for washing turned into wine for a wedding, and the jars never broken
- Servants who knew because they had obeyed, and a steward who did not
- A bridegroom congratulated for something he did not do
- Signs rather than mighty works - power that points past itself
- A whip used on the animals, and words used on the sellers of the poor man's dove
- My Father's house, said first and claimed as a son
- Destroy this temple, given as an imperative rather than a proposal
- Belief that He would not entrust Himself to
- A ruler who came at night and buried Him in daylight
- One word meaning both again and from above, and a conversation running on it
- A teacher of Israel told he had missed his own Scriptures
- Wind known by what it moves and not by where it began
- A cure shaped like the thing that was killing them
- Lifted up, meaning a cross and a throne in the same breath
- So loved, meaning in this way, and pointing back at a pole in the wilderness
- A judgment that is a preference rather than a sentence
- A friend of the bridegroom whose success is his own redundancy
- A great man's last recorded sentence, and it is about getting smaller

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May we know the One who was there before the beginning.

May the darkness in us neither put out His light nor fail to understand it.

May we receive Him, and be counted among the children born not of blood or will but of God.

May we behold His glory in the tent He pitched among us.

May we be full of grace and truth, and never trade one for the other.

May we be content to be a voice.

May we claim no title we have not been given.

May we behold the Lamb, and keep beholding Him.

May we bring our brother before we argue with a stranger.

May our answer to every objection be come and see.

May we be found without deceit, whatever our name used to mean.

May we see heaven opened over ordinary ground.

May we do whatever He tells us.

May we let Him fill what we already have rather than demanding something new.

May we be the servants who know because we obeyed.

May our zeal for His house never cool into commerce.

May we not need a sign to believe the One giving it.

May our believing be the kind He can entrust Himself to.

May we come in the dark if that is all we have, and come out in the daylight.

May we be born from above, and not merely improved.

May we stop asking how and start asking Him.

May we hear our own Scriptures before we ask for new ones.

May we go where the Spirit goes without demanding the map.

May we look straight at the thing lifted up for us.

May we never turn the cure into an idol.

May we love the light even when it shows us what we are.

May we receive only what heaven gives, and want nothing else.

May we rejoice to hear the Bridegroom’s voice.

May we be glad to become redundant.

May He increase, and may we decrease.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.